ADOLESCENTS

Persons between 10and 19 years of age



Stages of adolescence in boys and girls

Adolescence may be divided into three stages namely pre adolescene, early adolescence and late adoelscence

Table 4 Stages in Adolescence

Stages in adolescence	Girls (years)	Boys (years)
Pre-adolescence	10-12	11-13
Early adolescence	12-16	13-17
Late adoelscence	16-21	17-21

The period of adolescence is extremely important in one's life because at this stage, one moves from childhood to the onset of maturity. In every period of development from birth onwards a person may face many challenges due to the changes that occur during that period. Each phase in life has distinct characteristics.

Characteristics of the Adolescent Period

(i) Transitional period

Adolescence is a period of transition. During this phase the individuals status is vague and there is a confusion about the roles they are expected to play as they are neither children nor adults.

(ii) Period of change

The stage of adolescence is characterized by changes in physical, cognitive, social and emotional areas of their lives. This sets them apart and uniquely distinguishes them from other stages

(a) Physical changes

During adolescence, primary sex characteristics (the reproductive organs) develop and mature and secondary sex characteristics appear.

Primary Sex characteristics- In males, the testes grow rapidly during the first year or two of puberty. After that, the penis starts to grow in length and the seminal ducts and the prostate gland enlarge. The female uterus, fallopian tube and vagina grow rapidly through puberty. The ovaries produce ova and secrete the hormones needed for pregnancy, menstruation and the development of secondary sex characteristics.

Table 5 Secondary sex characteristics in adolescent boys and girls

Secondary sex characteristics	
Girls	**Boys**
Breasts develop	Pubic hair appear
Pubic hair appear	Axillary hair appear
Axillary hair appear	Facial hair and body hair appear
Increased width and depth of pelvis	Voice change

Source: Lefton, 1985

The secondary sex characteristics are those which are not directly tied to reproduction yet distinguish the male from the female species. The secondary

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